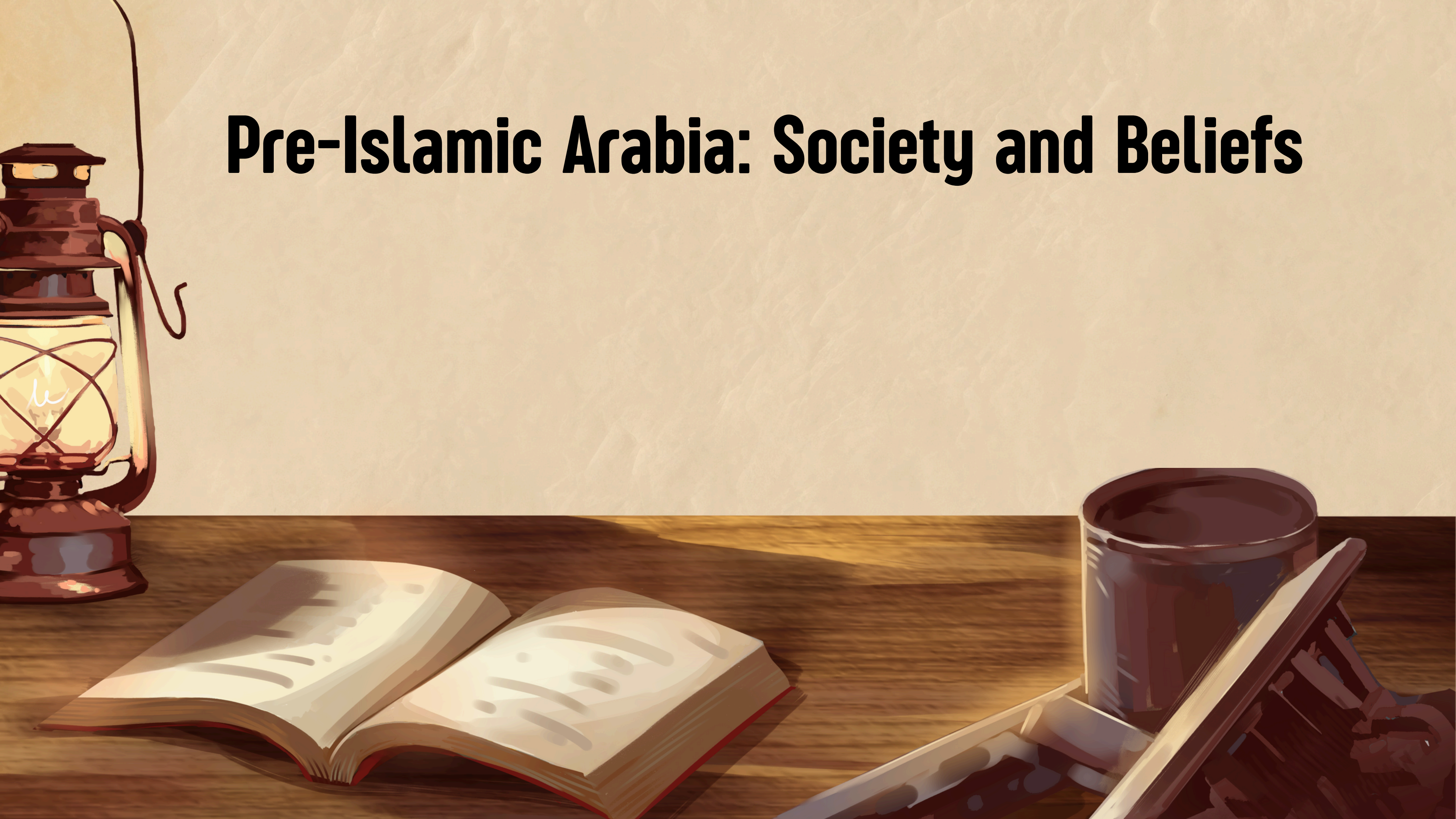


Pre-Islamic Arabia: Society and Beliefs



Aspects of Pre-Islamic Arab Society



- Society was structured around tribal identity, where honor and survival depended on the tribe.
- Social inequality was prominent:
 1. Strong tribes dominated weaker ones
 2. Slaves and women had limited rights
- Women's status was generally low:
 1. Female infanticide existed among some tribes
 2. Women were often treated as property
- Moral contradictions were common:
 1. High value on generosity, hospitality, and bravery
 2. Simultaneous prevalence of alcohol, gambling, adultery, and violence
- Economic life centered on:
 1. Trade caravans (especially Quraysh)
 2. Markets like 'Ukāẓ, Majannah, and Dhul-Majāz
- Poetry was the most powerful cultural expression:
 1. Poets were spokesmen of tribes
 2. Poetry preserved history, values, and rivalries
- Constant warfare shaped social life, with long-lasting tribal wars such as Bu'āth.
- Despite moral decay, Arabs possessed strong linguistic skill, memory, and courage, which later became tools for spreading Islam.





Religions of the Arabs

- The original religion of the Arabs was pure monotheism (Ḥanīfiyyah) traced back to Prophet Ibrāhīm (Abraham), but it became corrupted over time.
- Idolatry (shirk) became the dominant religious practice, with idols placed inside and around the Ka'bah.
- Famous idols included:
 1. Hubal (inside the Ka'bah)
 2. Lāt, 'Uzzā, and Manāt (major regional deities)
- Many Arabs believed idols were intercessors, not creators, claiming they brought them closer to Allah.
 1. Divination and superstition were widespread, including:
 2. Drawing lots with arrows
- Belief in omens, astrology, and jinn
- Judaism existed in regions like Yathrib (Madinah), Khaybar, and Yemen.
- Christianity was practiced in Najrān, Ghassān, and parts of Yemen and Syria.
- Some individuals known as Ḥunafā' rejected idol worship and searched for the true religion of Ibrāhīm.
- Despite religious diversity, moral guidance and spiritual clarity were largely absent.





Rule and Government among the Arabs

- Arabia had no single central government; political authority was fragmented and tribal in nature.
- Tribal leadership was the dominant system, where each tribe was headed by a shaykh (chief) chosen for wisdom, bravery, lineage, and generosity.
- The shaykh's authority was consultative, not absolute; major decisions were taken through tribal councils (shūrā).
- Loyalty was based on blood ties ('aṣabiyyah) rather than territory or law.
- Inter-tribal relations were governed by alliances (ḥilf), treaties, and mutual defense pacts.
- In Makkah, Quraysh held a more organized administrative structure, managing roles such as:
 1. Custodianship of the Ka'bah
 2. Providing water (Siqāyah) and food (Rifādah) to pilgrims
 3. War leadership and diplomacy
 4. Justice was custom-based, not codified law, often influenced by power, revenge, or tribal status.
 5. Blood feuds were common, and conflicts could continue for generations.

